

A Report on Online Violence in Africa During the Covid-19 Pandemic



With Covid-19 declared a pandemic, the World Health Organization (WHO) has, among other things, asked that citizens practise social distancing, self-isolation and quarantine as methods of mitigating the disease across the world. This has led to a large number of people confining themselves indoors.

Despite this, there are some notable initiatives rolled out by various institutions across the continent, to cushion its citizens from the hardships they are already facing and are likely to continue to face in the coming months.

Kenya



- In Kenya, the government announced a reduction in income tax from 30% to 25% to enable citizens to have access to more liquid cash, with employees earning Ksh. 24,000 or less set to receive 100% tax relief.
 - Safaricom has waived withdrawal charges for amounts less than Ksh 1,000, and doubled the limits of the permissible transaction from Ksh. 70,000 to Ksh. 140,000. In addition to this, the majority of the banks have waived bank to M-Pesa transaction costs. This move by the government and financial sector stakeholders was made to encourage Kenyans to go cashless and minimize hand-to-hand cash transactions.
 - Aside from the government, Kenyans have been building communities of care around mutual aid initiatives to provide the less privileged citizens with foodstuffs, and warm clothing for street families.
- Nigeria:

Nigeria



- Cash transfer initiatives have been activated at ₦20,000 in the northern part of Nigeria to low-income households.
- The Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN) introduced a ₦50 Billion Targeted Credit Facility (TCF) to support households and small & medium enterprises (SMEs) affected by the COVID-19 pandemic.
- The Lagos State Employment Trust Fund (LSETF) suspended the repayment of loans provided to SMEs and startups in the state.
- Nigeria's Private Sector Coalition against Covid-19, which is made up of the country's top industrialists and corporations has donated ₦25,893,699,791.00 to fight the pandemic.
- Nigerian banks reduced inter-bank transfer charges by 50%.

South Africa



- The South African government has rolled out a two-phase \$26B stimulus package to cushion the citizens, communities and businesses in South Africa for the coming six months from the side effects of the pandemic.
- The government will also assist companies facing distress through the Unemployment Insurance Fund and special programmes from the Industrial Development Corporation.

- Funds will be available to assist SMEs under stress, mainly in the tourism and hospitality sectors.

North Africa



- In Libya, the Tripoli government has allocated LD 75M from the nation's Emergency Fund to cushion them as they brave for the effects of the Covid-19 pandemic. The funds allocated to the four municipalities will provide the medical staff with protective gear and equipment as well as assist them to build proper quarantine and isolation centres.
- In Morocco, the government dedicated \$1B to curb the effects of the virus on the citizens. In addition, it has reduced the key interest rates to 2%.
- The Moroccan government is also working with the social security agency in the country to give the citizens a monthly allowance of 2,000 dirhams in addition to the family benefits and the nation's health insurance scheme.
- Tunisia is also progressively making strides to ensure its citizens are well-kept during the pandemic. Amongst some of its key moves, the government has allocated a total of 450M dinars to the technically unemployed workers, poor families and special-needs families who are directly affected by the crisis.
- Furthermore, the Tunisian government has also allocated 500M dinars to the local companies that stock food, drugs and oil to ensure continuous production and supply within the country.

The effects of a pandemic of this magnitude are far-reaching and social scientists will be analysing its effects on mankind for years to come. Nonetheless, some effects are already visible. Record levels of unemployment have been recorded in many parts of the world and many countries are struggling with an increase in domestic violence cases.

Unfortunately, the pandemic has also affected the online space. There is a marked decrease in online safety as the number of online scams have increased. There has been a significant increase in scam emails purported to be from Amazon, Paypal and various governments bent on parting people from their money. There is also a proliferation of COVID-19 scams.

Human rights defenders have noted an increase in the abuse of digital rights with companies like Zoom coming under fire for their continuous invasion of users' right to privacy. In addition to this, countries like Ghana and Nigeria are partnering with their communications service providers and using tracking apps to trace contacts of covid-19 patients using their subscribers' personal information. This is a move that, while great in tracking down and isolating potential positive cases, is troubling as it may be a gateway to misuse of citizens' right to privacy and may only be limited to individuals with access to smartphones or devices that monitor GPS information.

As most people around the world are confined in their homes, there has been a significant increase in the number of people using social media platforms. However, this has also caused a surge in online violence across online platforms. In documenting online violence from February 2020 to April 2020 we have observed the following:

Increase in Unlawful Dissemination of Images

On 1st April, the Kenyan government reported two successful recoveries from the Covid-19 virus, one man and one woman. They were then appointed as ambassadors to assist in campaigns aimed at mitigating the spread of the virus. However, as a result of the mistrust between Kenyans and their government, there was a heightened discourse on twitter around fact-checking government reports on the pandemic. This led to a group on Twitter, to illegally distribute intimate images belonging to the recovered female patient, an act that is punishable under Kenya's Computer Misuse and Cybercrimes Act 2018. This led to the victim being cyberbullied, harassed upon releasing a statement on her recovery.



A screenshot of a tweet from a Twitter user promoting online harassment and cyber bullying

During the Covid-19 pandemic, there has also been an increase in unconsented sharing of intimate images across the continent. One such case was highlighted in Ghana when a young man was recently convicted for sharing his ex-partner's intimate images without consent. The young man received a three-year sentence for the heinous and malicious act.

Ghana's case is only one. Several have been reported across the continent over the past few weeks with reported content being attended to at much slower rates.



A News Screenshot of woman's nude video shared online

Rise in Sinophobia in Africa

Sinophobia has also been on the rise on social media platforms recently with tweets and even media being created to target people of Asian descent as the source of the coronavirus. Some national leaders have been active participants in perpetuating this violence by naming the covid-19 virus, the “Wuhan virus”. This has led to both online and offline discrimination of Asians across the globe. In Kenya, this has especially grown immensely over the past two weeks as Kenyans, angry over posts showing their citizens being mistreated in China, took to social media to call for equal mistreatment of Chinese living in Kenya during the coronavirus pandemic. This was further heightened by a Kenyan politician suggesting that Kenyans were free to stone any unquarantined Chinese visitor they came across in the country.

Its not about kenya alone ..but Africa as a continent we would have revenge each any every single Chinese in Africa to send a signal that we are deadly serious. #ChineseInKenyaMustGo



A screenshot from Twitter calling for the punishment of Chinese foreigners

What is far more concerning, however, is the fact that while discrimination is on a dangerous rise, reporting mechanisms on these platforms seem to have slowed down.

Increased Calls for Sharing of Personal Identifiable Information

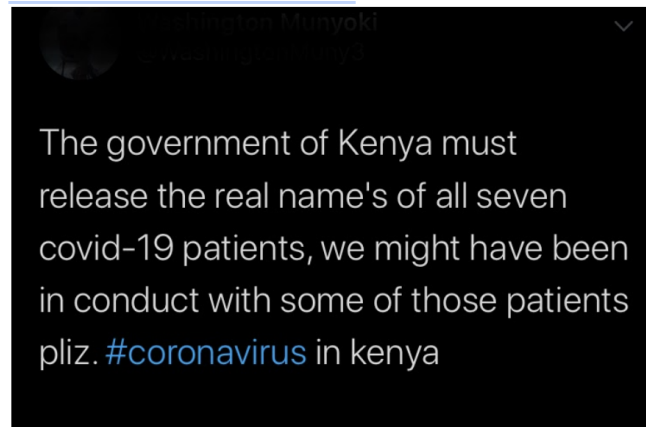
The act of revealing personal documents or details online about someone without their consent is called “Doxxing”. This can include personal information such as a person’s home address, real name, children’s names, phone numbers and email address. With fears over the spread of Covid-19, there have been calls on social media to publish the pictures, videos and identities of the infected.



Screenshot of a request on Twitter for a health regulatory body in Nigeria to release pictures & videos of Covid-19 patients

Releasing one's personally identifiable information is a harmful practise because it not only stigmatises the victim but also sets a target on their backs. This inspires other individuals to take action by chastising the sickly individuals.

This can easily and dangerously bubble into physical violent action. In Kenya, there have already been two cases of individuals losing out on a chance for proper healthcare because they were suspected of having the virus.



A screenshot from Twitter calling for the release of a Kenyan covid-19 patients' information

In another example, a popular Nigerian online Newspaper had initially published personal details of two patients' medical status in relation to Covid-19 testing, hence a warning of misconduct the ICT regulatory body in Nigeria, NITDA issued in a tweet to the erring online publisher's Twitter account.



Screenshot of Tweet from Nigeria's ICT Regulatory warning an erring online newspaper

Although the publication has since been pulled down from the publisher's website and the tweet linking to the published article also deleted, the ICT regulatory body maintained the warning, acknowledging the appropriate deletion and indicating that it was investigating up to 30 such similar cases of privacy infringement of medical patients in relation to Covid-19.

Targeted Misinformation and Fake News Leading to Online (and Offline) Violence

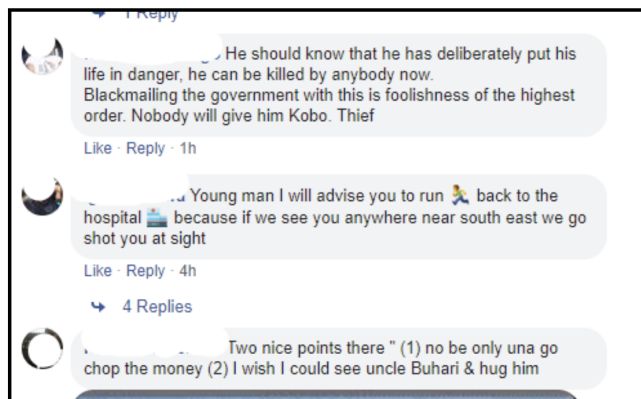
While fake news itself is not a form of online violence, it can incite violence both online and offline and during this coronavirus pandemic, 'fake news' is putting lives at risk.

According to the United Nations Educational, Scientific & Cultural Organization (UNESCO) unreliable and false information is spreading around the world to such an extent, that some commentators are now referring to the new avalanche of misinformation that has accompanied the COVID-19 pandemic as a 'disinfodemic'.

To buttress the point about fake news endangering lives offline, we look to an individual in Nigeria who began to receive death threats as a result of a number of publications using his picture as the cover image for a story that claimed an Uber driver who had driven the Nigerian Covid-19 index patient from the airport to his destination when the person first arrived in Nigeria from Italy was on the loose.



Screenshot of the parody Facebook page sharing fake news claiming a infected with Covid-19 threatened to spread it



Screenshot of verbal insults and threats in the comments section of the fake news post

The shared myth that black people were genetically protected from contracting the coronavirus fuelled the idea that the virus was brought into the continent by foreigners.

As reported by Al Jazeera, Kenyan locals believe that this virus was for the rich people and would not affect them and hence there was no reason to be taking extreme protective measures, despite the myth being debunked. This led to the physical harassment of Chinese residents in Nairobi with locals chanting to them that they were the coronavirus. This was further reflected in online discourses with some retorting that they deserved that treatment as punishment for bringing the coronavirus to Kenya.



A screenshot of the abuse that citizens of Asian descent have received since the onset of the corona virus in Africa

Increased Cyberbullying

There have also been reports indicating an increase in the cases of cyberbullying across the globe during the pandemic. A Kenyan artiste found himself a victim of this when Kenyans on Twitter trolled him on his craft as well as appearance. This disheartened the artiste prompting him to quit social media altogether. Similarly, a Kenyan female journalist, Betty Kyallo, is also a victim of cyberbullying as she has been continuously harassed by sections of Kenyans on social media regarding her personal life. This eventually triggered her severally to post a response standing her ground against her bullies. While this is laudable, not many have the courage to stand up to their faceless bullies on social media.

Cyberstalking and cyber-harassment have been on a significant and alarming rise in the past four months. The black lives matter movement sparked a global movement against police brutality and calling for the radical abolition of the institution of the police. In Kenya, citizens have been arrested for leading both online and offline protests, a direct reflection of the ways in which people's rights are continuously limited.

One young lady in Nigeria has been victim to harassment for the past few weeks after she took steps to name a Nigerian artiste, D'Banj, as the perpetrator that sexually abused her in 2018. As a reaction to the allegations, the musician not only had parts to play in an illegal arrest of the accuser, but her social media accounts were also allegedly taken over by his team, and her tweets were deleted. New tweets surfaced on the account praising D'banj and promoting his unreleased music.



A screenshot of the latest tweet from the lady's account bearing a press statement of rape and cyberstalking incident

These actions display the different crimes that can be committed across the online violence spectrum, from cyberstalking to harassment and identity theft.

Her story is not unique. Several women across the continent have similar experiences and were not protected from the harassment that came with speaking up about being sexually harassed and abused.

Reduced Online Tolerance for Opposing Views

With the Covid-19 pandemic, the intolerance for opposing views, especially on personal ideals, on social media is also noticeable with arguments arising every other day. Recently there were conversations around punishment by parents with supporting and others opposing caning as a form of discipline after a video of a parent slapping his child went viral. This sparked controversy on social media and insults being meted out against one another.

How Can We Build a Kinder Online Space for Ourselves and Others?

It is important to practise empathy and kindness as we navigate online spaces. A safe and healthy internet is in the interest of everyone who uses the internet. In building a safer and kinder internet we ask you to:



Verify ALL Information Before Sharing

The saying 'Information is power' is illustrated so well in these times. Sharing unverified information on the pandemic has far-reaching health implications.



Respect Privacy

The same way people respect physical privacy, a person's online privacy is just as important. Doxxing can cause individuals to socially exclude themselves and may lead to anxiety, depression among other mental health issues.



Report Abusers and Bullies

Most social media platforms have a "Report" function, it is important to use this function when others are being bullied or harassed. Encourage others to also call out bullies and harassers on their harmful behaviour, as it is said, there is power in numbers.



Support the Victims of Online Violence

While it may take a while for the action to be taken against bullies and perpetrators of online violence, it is important for us to avoid contributing to the issue at hand. It is more helpful to create online communities of care and safe spaces to support the victims.



Take Legal Action

During the covid-19 pandemic, it may take a while to get any progressive action against perpetrators of online violence via the reporting mechanisms on social media platforms. If this is the case for you, it is important to share these cases with advocates monitoring online violence in your country. For example, the International Federation of Women Lawyers (FIDA) is active in helping pursue cases of gender-based violence



Always Seek The Truth

Fake news isn't always spread maliciously, but regardless of the reason behind why it's shared, the result is generally the same: people on the receiving end believe that something wrong is actually right, or that something happened that never did.

At best, it may be a humorous meme. At worst, it might be inaccurate health information or false political information.



Amplify the Good Stories

There are many stories online of human kindness in the midst of the pandemic. Share those stories as much as you can as they connect us to a shared humanity.

Recommendations For The State



Developing and Implementing Policy On Online Violence

While several states already have regulations on cyber crimes and computer misuse, there is little to no legislation recognizing the severity of online violence. With a significant rise in online violence during the pandemic, the government needs to urgently review existing legislation and fill in the gaps in laws and policies that would systemically deal with online violence. This includes outlining what constitutes online violence, the government measures in curbing it, steps to take in addressing the forms of violence and penalties for participating in any of the activities outlined as forms of online violence.

Criminalizing online violence would go a long way in creating safer online spaces as citizens would be more aware of their actions.



Training Law Enforcement on Appropriate Response.

Governments across the continent need to provide technical and response training for local authorities on how to handle online violence with the same seriousness as offline violence. There is a need to debunk the idea that one can avoid online violence by simply logging off a device.

Recommendations For Civil Society Organizations (CSOs)



Create Awareness Campaigns

- Sensitizing the general public via social media platforms on their rights, the legitimacy, effects and repercussions of online violence.
- Organize stakeholder meetings with media houses, social media celebrities and influencers on how they can engage their fans/followers on ills of online violence.



Support Victims

- Provide relevant information on legal recourse.
- Provide relevant training, knowledge building and response mechanisms to law enforcement on how to combat online violence in their countries.
- Host knowledge sharing and co-creation sessions with organizations that work with some of the most targeted demographics (human rights defenders, journalists, female politicians and activists, persons in the LGBTQI community etc) on how to deal with online violence effectively.



Get Involved in Advocacy

- Advocate for the recognition and criminalization of online violence as a violation of human rights in countries with limited cybercrime laws.
- Advocate for the implementation, operationalization and enforcement of cybercrimes laws.

Recommendations For Trust and Safety Specialists



Increase The Responsiveness To Reports

There has been a slow-down in the rate of response via social media platforms to reported cases of online violence, understandably due to the pandemic changing the dynamics of working environments. However, there is a critical need for specialists within these platforms to respond sooner rather than later to online violence, and de-platforming harmful individuals who if left unchecked will continue perpetuating their harmful ideologies.



Escalate Cases with Local Law Enforcement

Where specialists note with concern threats of offline (physical) harm, they should alert the local authorities immediately so they can work to de-escalate the situation before it gets out of hand.

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